

BEFORE

After the fall of the Han dynasty, the Chinese empire divided into several kingdoms.



SUI DYNASTY
FIGURINE

ARRIVAL OF BUDDHISM

Buddhism **144–47** had been brought to China from the Indian subcontinent by the 2nd century CE. During the **period of division** that followed the fall of the Han dynasty **128–29**, Buddhism **spread quickly**, despite attempts to suppress the religion by Confucian officials. However, it was not until the Tang dynasty that **Buddhism was at the height of its influence** in China.

SUI DYNASTY

China was reunited in 589 CE under the **Sui dynasty**. The first Sui emperor, **Wendi**, built Chang'an (modern Xi'an), a **new capital city**, and enforced a **clear legal code**. His son, **Yangdi**, carried out a **costly program of canal building** and launched **ill-fated attacks on Korea**. The Sui dynasty fell to the Tang in 618 CE.

THE GRAND CANAL

The Sui emperor Yangdi commissioned a **Grand Canal** to run from Hangzhou to Beijing. The total length of the canal was 1,490 miles (2,400 km), and it remains **the longest canal in the world**.

CHINESE EMPRESS (625–705 CE)

WU ZETIAN

China's only empress to rule in her own right, Wu Zetian usurped the throne from her son the Ruizong emperor in 690 CE. Although judged to be a shrewd and ruthless ruler, she gave extravagant support to Buddhism and other foreign religions, and engaged in costly frontier campaigns. From 697 CE, she became enamored of the Zhang brothers. In 705 CE, her senior ministers had the brothers killed, and forced the empress to abdicate. She died later that year.



The reign of the Tang dynasty in China is widely regarded as a golden age of Chinese imperial power and culture. The dynasty itself was founded by Li Yuan, a frontier general, who in 617 rebelled against the Sui dynasty (see BEFORE). He took the capital Chang'an the following year, though it would be a further six years before the whole of China fell under his control. Under the title of Emperor Gaozu, Li Yuan inaugurated a new dynasty, which ruled over China for the next three centuries.

Taizong's reign

Gaozu's successor, the Emperor Taizong, was an intelligent and hard-working ruler, and his own reign (626–649 CE) became synonymous with a period of prosperity. Taizong improved the system of government that his father had established, and reformed the administrative system. State schools and colleges were set up, and government examinations were designed to ensure that the most talented individuals were placed in the highest official positions. For Taizong, this not only had the advantage of

monk, perhaps curious to hear Xuan Zang's impressions of foreign countries. Buddhism continued to have a great influence on Chinese society until its suppression in the late Tang period.

Expansion of the empire

The Tang dynasty saw a remarkable period of Chinese expansion. In 657 Taizong's armies defeated the Turks at

the battle of Issyk Kul in modern-day Kyrgyzstan, and advanced China's influence as far west as the borders of Persia. Taizong also launched expeditions against the kingdom of Koguryo in north Korea, though he died before he had established Chinese control over the area. At its greatest extent, in around the year 750 CE, Tang China claimed more land than the preceding

Han dynasty, its borders reaching even farther west, south, and east than those of modern China.

Xuanzong's golden age

Following the reign of the ruthless Wu Zetian (see left) and several other short-lived rulers, the succession fell to the Emperor Xuanzong in 712 CE.

“Have I not heard
that **pure wine**
makes a **sage**,
And even
muddy wine
Can make a
man **wise?**”

FROM “DRINKING ALONE IN THE
MOONLIGHT” BY LI BAI, C. 701–62 CE

China's Golden Age

The peak of the Tang dynasty (618–907 CE) saw the flowering of Chinese art, architecture, and poetry. Silk Road caravans brought exotic goods from distant lands, and Chinese culture became the most cosmopolitan in the world.

delivering an efficient civil service, but also strengthened his own security. Unlike those drawn from China's rival aristocratic families, career officials had no power base of their own with which to threaten the Tang dynasty.

The rise of Buddhism

Though he promoted Confucianism and Daoism (see p.127) within the bureaucracy, Taizong personally embraced the Buddhist religion imported from India (see BEFORE). In 629 CE, the monk Xuan Zang journeyed to India to collect Buddhist texts. His travels were the inspiration for the famous Chinese novel *Record of a Journey to the West*, better known in the West as *Monkey*. When he returned to China in 645 CE, Taizong received the

Xuanzong was a clever and diligent ruler, and in the first part of his reign the fortunes of the Tang dynasty were revived. Sweeping reforms were made to the bureaucracy; large granaries were constructed to stockpile rice; military campaigns were fought against the Turkish, Tibetan, and Khitan peoples; a new network of frontier defenses was introduced, with permanent forces of professional soldiers; and contact was made with ambassadors from as far west as the Middle East. All of these measures led to a rich, powerful, and cosmopolitan state; China had reached a golden age.

As China's territory expanded, so did its cultural influence. Thousands of merchants, artisans, and diplomats from distant lands took up residence in the capital, Chang'an, which became



The Giant Buddha at Leshan

At 233 ft (71 m) tall, this stone Buddha in the Sichuan region of China is the world's tallest. Its construction began in 713 CE.

Little Goose Pagoda, Xi'an

Still standing today, this 15-story pagoda was built between 707 CE and 709 CE to house scriptures of the Buddhist faith.

